owned banks. Washington then imposed a trade embargo on Cuba. In October 1960 Eisenhower banned all exports to Cuba, save for medicines and some foodstuffs.

Many in the US retained an ideological hostility to public ownership in the way that many Europeans, for example, did not. Yet nationalisation of US companies in Cuba amounted to expropriation and inevitably meant conflict with Washington. There were also potentially serious implications for US economic interests across Central and South America. The Cuban government, and particularly Che Guevara, sought to promote revolution in Central and South America, which threatened regional stability and US economic and political interests.

In July 1960 Khrushchev was exercised about competition with Mao over Cuban affections (at a time when the strategic alliance between Moscow and Beijing was faltering) and spoke publicly of using Soviet ICBMs in Cuba's defence. It was pure bluff. The Soviets possessed only four ICBMs. Boasting about Soviet missile technology became a trademark of Khrushchev's political rhetoric and reflected his bombastic and threatening style.

Moscow's relationship with Havana developed incrementally. The first significant shipments of arms from the Eastern Bloc arrived in September 1960. Khrushchev's rhetoric, however, proved counterproductive. His words fuelled fear of nuclear war and the perception of many people (and their elected representatives) that Moscow was winning the nuclear arms race. In November 1956 Khrushchev had issued a warning to the West, which was translated as: 'Whether you like it or not, history is on our side. We will bury you.' [25] While his aim was to emphasize the inevitable triumph of communism over capitalism, many Americans thought less about the onward march of dialectical materialism and more about building a fallout shelter. Moreover, many (and their elected representatives) thought about building more missiles.

Castro made another visit to the United States in September 1960, when he addressed the United Nations General Assembly in New York (attired in olive green battle dress). His speech lasted four hours twenty-minutes and entered the Guinness Book of Records as the longest ever delivered in the